



It Was Just a Joke

"It was just a joke" is what gets said when a joke has landed badly, and it usually closes the conversation down rather than sorting it out. Students sort six ordinary moments into joke, not a joke and cannot tell, then work out for themselves what actually separates them. They come away with four questions for telling one from the other, and with something better to say than that sentence.

Before you start. This one sits close to whatever is already going on in your form, so do not use a real incident or a real name, and do not run it the day after one. Slide 8 lists the subjects students in the research put over the line, and one of them is somebody who has died, so check who that would land on before you show it. The same research also named self-harm, which is left off the slide on purpose; if a student raises either, follow it up outside the room in the usual way.

Print these

Page	What it is	How many
Pages 2 and 3	The answer key: the four questions, what to say, and the sources	One set, for you
Page 4	The sheet they write on	One per student
Page 5	Eight moment cards	One set, cut up

The hour

Time	What happens	Slides
7 min	In pairs, sort six moments into joke, not a joke and cannot tell, then reveal that they were three pairs and what changed inside each one.	3 to 4
9 min	Teach the four questions, then take the sentence apart: it says two things at once and only one of them is an apology.	5 to 6
6 min	Pairs predict what is always off limits, then see what the students in the study named.	7 to 8
9 min	Model one answer that works and one that backfires, then the three to use if you said it and the three for when it was about you.	9 to 11
15 min	Do one together out loud, then twelve minutes in pairs writing the words for both people, on the sheet.	12 to 13
6 min	Sheets move two tables along and get marked against the three questions.	14
7 min	Discuss whether something can be a joke and still be worth stopping, then the exit ticket, kept by the student.	15 to 16

Worth knowing

- The starter only works while the pairing is hidden. If a student spots it early, ask them to sit on it until the feedback.

Most of them will still use the sentence. What changes is what they say next.





The starter, and the four questions

The starter is not marked, but it does have an answer, and the four questions come out of it rather than being handed down. This page is what to have in front of you.

The six moments were three pairs

Pair	What changed	What to say about it
A and D	Whether it stopped	One of them went both ways and ended there. The other one carried on all week.
B and E	Who was laughing	One of them has the person laughing too. The other has an audience, and they are not.
C and F	Whose it is	A nickname you made up for yourself is yours. One somebody else gave you three years ago is not.

The four questions, in full

Ask this	What it catches
Is the person it is about laughing?	Not smiling, and not laughing a beat late. This is the one students find hardest, because everybody in the room usually knows the answer already.
Would you say it to them with nobody else there?	This separates being funny from performing. A line that needs an audience was aimed at the audience, not at the person.
Could they say the same thing back to you, and would it still be funny?	This is the power question without using the word. It catches the things nobody can answer back: how somebody looks, what their family is like, what they find hard.
Did it stop the first time they asked?	The clearest of the four and the easiest to check. Everything before the first ask can be a mistake. Everything after it is a choice.

The two sources

Where it comes from	What it found
Steer, O., Betts, L. R., Baguley, T. and Binder, J. F. (2020)	"I feel like everyone does it": adolescents' perceptions and awareness of the association between humour, banter, and cyberbullying. Computers in Human Behavior, 108, 106297. Focus groups with 28 students aged eleven to fifteen at two secondary schools in the English Midlands. They described a line of acceptability that depends on friendship, trust and who is watching rather than on the words used, and they named much the same subjects as being over it.
Anti-Bullying Alliance and Nottingham Trent University (2023)	Banter or Bullying? Navigating the line of acceptability. A toolkit for schools, built on a survey of 884 teachers. Nineteen per cent said they felt equipped to deal with banter, against thirty-seven per cent for bullying, and eighty-four per cent had had no training on it at all.





What to say instead

The one place in this lesson where you have to come up with something on the spot is the round you do together on slide 12. These are the answers to have ready, for both people in the moment.

If you said it: words that work

What they say	Why it works
"That came out worse than I meant it to. Sorry."	It keeps the true half of the sentence and drops the half that ends the conversation.
"Fair enough, I will leave it."	Nobody has to admit anything, which is why it usually works in front of other people.
"You are right. I will stop."	It answers the only question that matters at the time, which is whether it carries on.

If you said it: what sounds fine and does not work

What they say	What happens
"It was just a joke."	It asks the person who was hurt to take it back for you, in front of everybody who heard it.
"You are too sensitive."	It moves the conversation from what was said to what is wrong with them.
A long apology in front of the whole group.	It makes it into a scene, and the audience was the problem in the first place.

If it was about you

What they say	Why it works
"I know you did not mean it, but I do not like it."	It gives them the true half back, and it is the sentence that makes question four possible.
"Leave it, yeah?"	Short, no scene, and most people stop.
Say it later, on their own.	Away from the audience it is a different conversation, and it usually goes better.

What the sentence is doing

The half people mean	The half people hear
I did not mean to hurt you.	Now stop talking about it.





TUTOR TIME · IT WAS JUST A JOKE

What I would actually say

Take one card between two. Write the words you would really use, not the ones that sound good. Nobody collects this.

THE MOMENT ON OUR CARD

WHICH OF THE FOUR DOES IT FAIL?

Circle every one it fails.

1 Laughing?	2 On their own?	3 Both ways?	4 Stopped?
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What the person who said it should say

What the person it was about could say

MARKED BY SOMEBODY ELSE

Tick each one it passes.

Could they say it out loud?	Nobody put on trial?	Both people let out of it?
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One change that would get it said





Eight moments

Cut along the dashed lines. One card between two, and they last as long as the paper does.

MOMENT 1

Somebody does an impression of a classmate's accent and the group laughs. The classmate laughs too, then goes quiet for the rest of the lesson.

Which question does it fail, and what would you say?

MOMENT 2

A nickname that started in Year 7 is still going, and the person it is about has asked twice for it to stop.

Which question does it fail, and what would you say?

MOMENT 3

A group has a running joke about how quiet somebody is, and says it every time they speak.

Which question does it fail, and what would you say?

MOMENT 4

A group is laughing about what somebody wore at the weekend, and that person walks in.

Which question does it fail, and what would you say?

MOMENT 5

Somebody keeps saying a classmate only got picked for the team because of who their friend is.

Which question does it fail, and what would you say?

MOMENT 6

Two people keep saying a classmate is obsessed with somebody, in front of both of them.

Which question does it fail, and what would you say?

MOMENT 7

A friend repeats to you, laughing, the things other people have been saying about your work.

Which question does it fail, and what would you say?

MOMENT 8

Somebody says something about a classmate's family and then says they did not mean it like that.

Which question does it fail, and what would you say?

